

Total Cost of Ownership, TCO, you must have surely run into this TLA (Three Letter Acronym) on the Byzantine streets of technology and consumerism. It must have peddled its salient features to you, likely that it pleaded with you to consider it closely before buying a printer. Good advice, listen to TCO before making that decision. We would like to point out however, that the concept extends to more than a printer, its cartridge and the number of pages that it prints per minute.

Every time you struggle with your sound card driver, or with your digital camera software, you are wasting your time, wasting your money. Consider the case of Vivek Pannu, a computer engineer from Hissar in Harayana, and his LG CD-Writer. Vivek, and

the drive in question, have a difference of opinion—while Vivek wants the drive to perform its civic duties, the recalcitrant Writer disagrees. Thus he has to take his drive to the nearest LG service centre, back and forth, wasting both precious time and money. “I was really humiliated by the service centre,” he bemoans, “I burnt petrol worth my CD-Writer.” TCO at its worst, he had to pay an additional amount of money just to get a piece of hardware working.

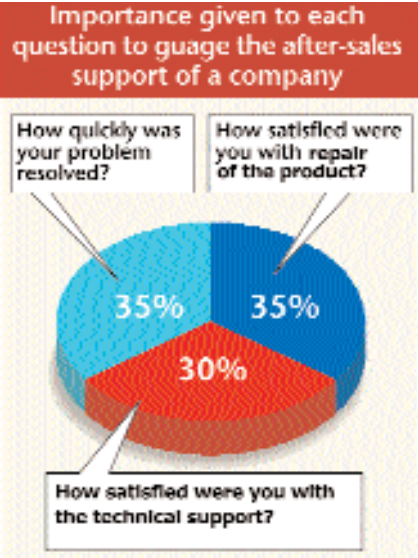
This is where the concept of Service and Reliability steps in. How frequently does a product break down? Does a company offer good after-sales service? Where are its service centres present? Does it have any call centres? How helpful are its technical staff? Did they solve your problem?... questions

to that effect need to be asked. These factors determine the true worth of your purchase. Is your MP3 player a good buy in the long run, or is it a money drain forcing you to spend hundreds on its battery every month?

How do you measure something like this? We decided to ask you, for surely there can be no better public to ask than one that buys and deals with technology on a daily basis. The exercise was performed as a survey—asking the right questions and logging the answers, the results were then fed into the Digit Supercomputer (a bunch of diligent geeks that live on numbers), and analysed for ease of digestion. We present the results of the survey: everything from cell phones to desktop computers, how reliable is that product you are planning to buy? Find out.

The Method behind the Numbers

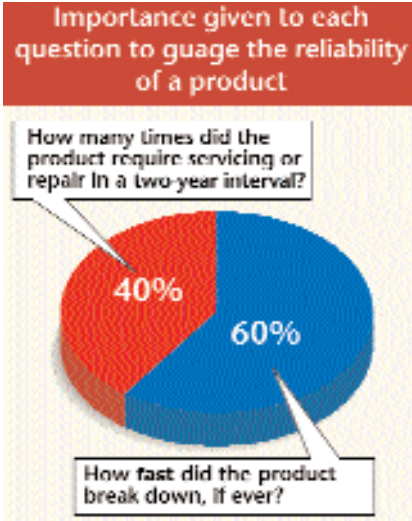
We first prepared a list of questions to help crystallize reader experience with a particular product. For example, queries to the nature of “When did your product first break down?”,



along with “How many times did your product need servicing or repair within a 2-year period?”, helped us get a handle on the reliability of a particular product; similarly questions were formed to gauge the quality of after-sales support that a company offered. The questionnaire was posted on our Web site: www.thinkdigit.com. Readers were invited to offer their feedback through two means: by replying to an insert in *Digit* magazine, or as an e-mail request to take the survey. Both the methods were tagged with a unique numerical identifier. A respondent would log onto the survey page using this number and once logged off, the identifier would expire. This ensured that there was no duplication in responses.

The response sample was 2012, based on which a statistical analysis was done to determine, amongst other things, the Reliability and Service Index. To understand the importance given to each question, please see the accompanying pie-charts.

From the Reliability Index (RI) and the Service Index (SI), an Overall Satisfaction Grade (OSG) was generated for the categories involved. The grade was meant to indicate how a particular company fared overall: taking both reliability and service into consideration, within a sub-category. To do so, the indices in question were averaged with a weightage in mind: both RI and SI were awarded a 50-50 split up; there were a few exceptions to this rule, which are duly noted in the accompanying table. As an example the hard disks were given a 70 per cent importance on the matter of reliability (RI), and a 30 per cent importance was given to



their Service Index (SI). A company that scored the highest OSG was awarded the Digit Icon of Trust.

Finally, we determined a Mode for the entire industry—covering all categories—from cell phones to desktop computers. This mode figured as 4.5 for the Reliability Index and 3.0 for the Service Index. To put things into perspective, when a sub-category earns an average mark of 4.0 on the Reliability Index, it would translate into the fact that the particular sub-category is well below the industry standard, as far as reliability is concerned. As an example, the digital camera sub-category (consisting of companies ranging from Sony to Creative), scored an overall Reliability Index of 4.54, just above the industry (consisting of all surveyed sub-categories from digital cameras to notebook computers) standard of 4.5.

In each sub-category only those that received over 5 per cent of the votes or 10 votes (whichever was higher), were considered qualified for analysis. This cut-off was essential to remove any generated bias due to a low number of vote-count in that sub-category.

A certified survey

The research process was verified and certified by The Research Pacific Group, which is headquartered in Singapore and has presence all across the Asia-Pacific region. The Research Pacific Group is a full service marketing research provider, which has conducted research throughout Asia for over 12 years; its core competency is providing ‘Best In Class’ customised Marketing Research solutions throughout Asia.

Overall Satisfaction Grade (OSG)		
Product	RI	SI
CD Writers	50	50
Cell Phones	60	40
Desktop	50	50
Digicam	50	50
Display	50	50
HDD	70	30
Laptop	60	40
MP3 Player	50	50
Printer	50	50
Scanner	50	50
Sound Card	50	50